

PLUMS, DAMSONS, AND GAGES

Prunus spp.

With their beautiful blossom and their sweet, juicy fruits that are excellent for use in jams, desserts, pies, and crisps, there is every reason to want to grow your own plum tree. Their close relative the gages are even richer in flavor and are wonderful eaten fresh from the tree. Damsons are too sharp to eat raw but are delicious cooked.

	SPRING	SUMMER	FALL	WINTER
PLANT				
HARVEST				

PLANTING

Plums, damsons, and gages all need a well-drained soil with a pH of about 6.5, and a warm, sunny position. A south-facing wall is ideal; frost pockets should be avoided. You need to select the right variety and rootstock for your garden, since not all plum trees are self-fertile. If you opt for trees that aren't, ensure that they flower at the same time in the season and that the combination you choose are compatible, since some trees will simply not pollinate each other. If in doubt, seek the advice of a specialist when you buy your trees.

Choose a rootstock that works for your space. Plum trees can grow quite large, so if you don't have a large plot choose a



Protect blossom from early frosts

semi-dwarfing rootstock. If you choose a semi-vigorous type, ensure that trees have enough room to spread as they get older. Leave about 22 ft (7 m) between freestanding trees, but less if you are training the tree into a fan or cordon shape, since it will require less space.

Container-grown trees can be planted at any time of year, provided that the weather is